

FIELD OF VISION **SHARDA UGRA**

Together Alone Again



So they're together again. Again. Leander Paes and Mahesh Bhupathi, India's best ever doubles team, should have been linked forever like Rodgers & Hammerstein or hell, even strawberries and cream. Today they are closer to Tom and Jerry or, to reduce their feud to the totally farcical, as it should be, Harbhajan Singh and Sreesanth.

A few weeks after Bhupathi said he'd rather not partner Paes at the Beijing Olympics, the former three-time Grand Slam doubles champs have been pushed into a compromise by the All India Tennis Association (AITA). They will play their fourth Olympics together in Beijing, all for the "sake of the nation". At this stage, you wouldn't really blame the nation if it said, 'Gee guys, thanks but honestly, don't bother. It's fine, we'll understand'.

At first India didn't understand at all. Here were two equally personable young men who were just so *fun* on a

tennis court that it was hard to believe they could barely speak to each other. When their team finally broke up in 2002 after winning 23 titles together, it predictably split Indian tennis in two. In a reprise of Amritraj vs Krishnan, this 20th century Indian tennis face-off quickly divided the Davis Cup team and took the tennis press corps with it. Today, it's not even an interesting story anymore for the fatigued faithful, just a series of recurring, reciprocal slights.


SAURABH SINGH

The best way to deal with Bhupathi-Paes these days is to convince yourself that today for each man, the other does not exist. That the fabulous doubles team was somebody else altogether. It works as long as no one tries to manufacture an artificial truce, which the AITA does every four years. For the record, it's never worked. At least, Tom and Jerry is funny and Bhajji and Sree is over.

At their last outbreak of hostilities around the Davis Cup ties against Uzbekistan and Japan, a fellow player offered another suggestion for breaking the impasse. Give the two men boxing gloves, put them in a wwf-style cage, lock the door and whoever remained standing at the end of the bout could claim the keys and go home the winner. "I just want it to end, man", he confessed wearily.

A few months more and, one way or another, hopefully it will end in Beijing—this time really for the 'sake of the nation'. As Bhupathi and Paes head off on this uneasy mission, the 'nation' can only make a request: however messy it gets, keep the mess out of sight. Whatever you do, fellas, don't do it in the open. Other than playing tennis and maybe winning a medal.



UNDER FIRE:
Chauhan

Treading on Eggshells

BHOPAL While Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan has publicly welcomed the recent income tax raids across the state to unravel corruption, it may have been the last thing he wanted. With Assembly elections barely six months away, the Chauhan Government is grappling with the fall-out of the raids over May 30-31 and June 1 on the homes and offices of high-profile targets, including relatives of Health Minister Ajay Vishnoi, Home Secretary Rajesh Rajora and Director of Health Department Dr Ashok Sharma. The raids were conducted on 55 premises across Bhopal, Indore, Jabalpur and other places. They uncovered unaccounted cash, valuables and benami properties worth crores.

The timing comes as a boon to the Opposition Congress. The raids came within a fortnight of Pradesh Congress Committee chief Suresh Pachouri levelling allega-

tions of massive corruption in the Health Department and lodging a complaint with the anti-corruption ombudsman Lok Ayukta against Vishnoi. The Congress has also lodged a number of complaints with the Lok Ayukta against some ministers and top officials. In May, the Lok Ayukta had recommended cancellation of two plots of prime land allotted by the Indore Development Authority to the saffron-affiliated trust, Guruji Sewa Sangh.

While the actual yield of the sensational raids will be known later, the Congress is already on the offensive. After three days of stout refusal and counter-charge of the raids being engineered by the Congress to malign the BJP Government, Bishnoi resigned on the insistence of the party's top leadership in Delhi.

Clearly, the path for Chauhan to a victory in Madhya Pradesh in the next polls is littered with minefields.

by Ambresh Mishra